

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 2
 ♥ Q J 10 8
 ♦ 9 5
 ♣ K J 9 3

♠ K Q 3

♥ 9 6 4

♦ A Q 7 3

♣ 6 4 2



♠ 8 6 4

♥ A K 3

♦ K J 10 2

♣ A 8 7

♠ J 10 9 5

♥ 7 5 2

♦ 8 6 4

♣ Q 10 5

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT

3NT by South

If East held the ♠A you would not have made the contract.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 7

Needing two more winners you will have to make both the ♠K and ♠Q. This will only be possible if West holds the ♠A. Win the first trick (if you don't West might switch to ♣s) and play a small ♠ toward dummy's ♠Q. It holds the trick.

You should take your four ♦ winners now, being sure to end up in your hand. Then play another small ♠ toward dummy's ♠K. This also wins.

You have now won 7 tricks so don't mess around now. Take your two Aces and let them have the last four tricks.

A Simple Finesse has only a 50% success rate. That's why we only take finesses as a last resort.

Board 2

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 4 3
♥ 9 8 2
♦ K J 6 3
♣ J 9 7

♠ 9 8 6

♥ A K Q J 4

♦ A 7 4

♣ A 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K J 5 2

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10

♣ K Q 10 5

♠ A Q 7

♥ 10 6

♦ 9 8 5 2

♣ 8 6 4 3

West

North

East

South

1♥

Pass

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South
other half they lose.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ 3.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need just one more winner. Since West probably has 4 ♦s you will not be able to establish a trick in that suit, so your only hope is the ♠Q. You win the first ♦ so they don't get a chance to switch to ♣s, a suit you are worse off in. Then take your 5 ♥ tricks, ending in dummy.

You can't put it off any longer so play a small ♠ from dummy and put the ♠Q on. If it wins you will make your contract, if it loses you won't.

East held the ♠K so you were lucky this time.

But remember, finesses only work half the time. The

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

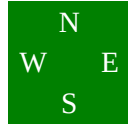
♠ A 10 7
 ♥ Q J 10 9
 ♦ J 7 4
 ♣ 10 6 3

♠ 6 5 3

♥ 8 6 4 2

♦ K 6

♣ K J 5 2



♠ Q J 9 4

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10 9 2

♣ 9 4

♠ K 8 2

♥ A K

♦ A 8 5 3

♣ A Q 8 7

West	North	East	South
	Pass	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South

Welcome to the real world.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

Needing one more winner you should see right away that it cannot come from ♥s, ♦s, or ♣s. That means you must hope that East has the ♠A. Win the first ♥, then play your 4 ♣ winners ending in dummy.

The moment of truth. You lead a small ♠ from dummy. East plays low and you play the ♠K.

Unfortunately West takes your ♠K with the ♠A. He then plays another ♥ and you at least make 8 tricks but have no hope for a ninth one so you go down 1.

You probably thought since these Deals were all about finesses that they would work all of the time.

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q 9 3

♥ 10

♦ K 10 6 5

♣ 10 7 3 2

♠ 8 6 2

♥ 8 4 3 2

♦ A Q 7 4

♣ 9 5



♠ J 10 5

♥ A 6

♦ J 9 3 2

♣ A 8 6 4

♠ A 7 4

♥ K Q J 9 7 5

♦ 8

♣ K Q J

West

North

East

South

Pass

2♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by South

At this point you have not lost any tricks, and you can see that you have only 3 losers remaining in your hand. So you start pulling trumps and establishing the ♣s.

If the ♦ finesse had lost you would have gone down 2 instead of just one.

The risk was worthwhile though since it gave you your only chance of making the contract.

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

West found the best opening lead for his side, exposing your ♠ losers before you could establish the ♣ suit for a discard. If you start to pull trumps right away the defense will grab the ♥A, then take their two ♠ tricks and you will still have the ♣A that you cannot avoid.

Other than the ♦A the only useful card in dummy is the ♦Q so you must try to make a winner out of that for a discard. So win the ♠A, lead your singleton ♦ and finesse the ♦Q. Your luck has returned, the ♦Q wins and you discard one of your ♠ losers on the ♦A.

Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 7 3

♥ K 8 3

♦ 6 2

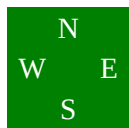
♣ Q 9 6 4

♠ A Q J 2

♥ 9 7 6

♦ A K 5

♣ A J 10



♠ 6 4

♥ J 10 5 4

♦ 9 4 3

♣ K 7 5 2

♠ K 9 5

♥ A Q 2

♦ Q J 10 8 7

♣ 8 3

West

North

East

South

1 ♣

Pass

2NT

Pass

6NT

All Pass

6NT by South

DO NOT FINESSE THE ♥. Stick with your original 75% plan. Take the ♥A and play your small ♣, finessing the ♣J. This is why you couldn't discard a ♣ earlier.

The single ♥ finesse is an inferior play because its success depends on East holding a specific card, the ♥K.

The double ♣ finesse is much better because its success depends on West holding either of two cards, the ♣Q **OR** the ♣K.

South is to play 6NT. West leads the ♠3.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=1 ♦=5 ♣=1 Total = 11

You need one more winner from the ♥ or ♣ suit. The straight finesse of the ♥K offers a 50% chance of success. The double finesse of the ♣K Q offers a 75% chance of success. It's a no-brainer. Run 4 ♠s and 5 ♦s ending in your hand. Be very careful not to discard a ♣ from your hand.

[showcards N:H9,CA,CJ,CT S:HA,HQ,C8,C3]

Lead a small ♣ and play the ♣10 if West plays low. Let's say East wins the ♣K and returns a ♥.

[showcards N:H9,CA,CJ S:HA,HQ,C8]

Board 6

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 6 5

♥ 10 8 3

♦ K Q J 10 7

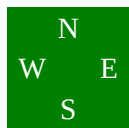
♣ 8 4 2

♠ 4 3

♥ 7 5 2

♦ A 6 5 3

♣ J 10 9 5



♠ K 7 2

♥ K 9 6 4

♦ 9 2

♣ K 7 6 3

♠ A Q J 10 9 8

♥ A Q J

♦ 8 4

♣ A Q

West

North

East

South

Pass

2♦

Pass

2♣

Pass

2NT

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by South

surely still have a ♥ loser. But if you finesse the ♣K successfully you will eliminate your ♣ loser.

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

West has made another great lead. Any other suit would have given you a free finesse. You should duck the first ♦. It is very possible that West has led from ♦ K Q 10 and will be afraid to continue for fear you have the ♦J in your hand. You'd be very happy to see him switch to any other suit. But he doesn't, he continues with the ♦Q which you take with dummy's ♦A.

You are in dummy for the first, last, and only time. You need to try a finesse right now, but which one? At first you might think it makes no difference but, in fact, there is only one reasonable choice. If you finesse the ♠K successfully you may still have a ♠ loser. If you finesse the ♥K successfully you will

What a great layout! Three possible finesses and every one of them would work.

But as you can see, only the ♣ finesse will actually save you a trick.